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# Three Questions Wellness Is Actually Asking

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Most people who walk into a wellness appointment are not thinking about wellness as a concept. They are thinking about a specific thing they want to be different. They want to feel less depleted. They want to recover what an injury or a season of stress took from them. Or they have a quieter, harder-to-name sense that something in their life could be more integrated, more whole. These are three genuinely different desires. In 37 years of practice, I have seen them require genuinely different things from the people doing the work. And the failure to distinguish between them is where most wellness relationships quietly break down.

*This is not a problem of wrong treatment. It is a problem of wrong question.*

## THE QUESTION UNDERNEATH THE APPOINTMENT

Wellness is often talked about as if it exists on a single spectrum, with sick at one end and thriving at the other, and practitioners guiding clients steadily from left to right. That model is tidy. It is also wrong. What it misses is that three different clients can walk through the same door in the same week, all technically pursuing wellness, and be asking three completely different questions.

The first question is: how do I protect what I already have?

The second is: how do I get back what I lost?

The third is: how do I become more of who I actually am?

These are not three intensities of the same goal. They are three different orientations toward the body, the self, and what care even means. When I hear all three as variations of help me feel better, I have already started the relationship on uncertain ground. I have made that mistake. I know what it costs.

## Preservation Is Not the Easy One

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There is a tendency, sometimes unspoken, to treat preservation as the least urgent category. I have caught myself doing it. If someone comes in without pain, without a recovery story, and without a crisis, it is easy to unconsciously underweight what they bring. But a client who comes in to maintain something is operating from clarity, not complacency. They know what they have. They have decided it is worth protecting. That decision took something.

The work here is precise and often underestimated. It asks me to understand the current baseline well enough to distinguish useful challenge from unnecessary disruption. It asks the client to stay engaged with something that does not feel broken. Both of those are harder than they sound.

What I have learned is that getting preservation wrong usually looks like over-intervention. I am trained to solve problems, and sometimes I start solving a problem that was not there. The client starts to feel that maintenance was not enough of a reason to be here. The relationship drifts.

II

## Restoration Is Not a Straight Line Back

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When someone comes to me needing restoration, there is often an implicit agreement that we are both working toward a return. Back to how things were before the injury. Before the burnout. Before the diagnosis. That return is sometimes possible and always worth moving toward. But I have seen that agreement become a problem when it goes unexamined.

Recovery is rarely a straight line back to a previous state. The body that went through something is not the same body that comes out the other side. I have worked with clients who assumed restoration meant erasure of what happened, and I have quietly agreed with that assumption myself, and we were both confused when the work hit a wall that had nothing to do with effort or technique.

*“What I have come to understand is that the real work of restoration is not recreation. It is reorientation.”*

It asks both of us in the room to stay honest about what recovery can actually mean for this specific person at this specific point in their life.

III

## Wholeness Is Not the Destination for Everyone

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Wholeness tends to attract a certain romanticized framing in wellness spaces. I have used that framing myself and later regretted it. It gets positioned as the most evolved goal, the one you arrive at after you have done the real work. That framing is worth pushing back on directly.

Wholeness is not a graduation. It is a specific orientation toward care, one that asks about integration rather than repair or maintenance. A client oriented toward wholeness is not asking what is wrong with them or how to hold onto what is good. They are asking who they are becoming and whether their habits, their relationships, and their choices are in alignment with that.

This is not a more serious question than the others. It is a different one. And I have watched it become the wrong question for clients who actually needed to restore something before they could do anything else. Pushing someone toward integration when they are still in the middle of recovery is not ambitious care. It is a mismatch.

## The Mismatch Is the Problem

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Most friction in a wellness relationship does not come from the wrong treatment. It comes from the practitioner answering a different question than the one the client is actually asking.

A client who came in for preservation and keeps being asked about their deeper goals will feel misread. A client who came in for wholeness but is only offered symptom management will feel reduced. A client who came in for restoration and gets handed a growth-oriented framework before they have stabilized will feel abandoned. I have been on the wrong side of all three of those.

None of these outcomes require bad intentions. They require only the assumption that wellness is one goal with different intensities, and that the practitioner knows which intensity the client needs.

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*Answering the right treatment to the wrong question is still the wrong answer.*

The fix is not a longer intake form. It is an earlier, more honest conversation about which question is actually being asked. Not what the client wants to feel. Not what I think they need. What question brought them here.

## Knowing Which Question You Are In

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At Higher Purpose Wellness Spa, the work of supporting clients through these three orientations starts with the recognition that each one is complete. None of them is a stepping stone to another. None of them is the one a client should want. The only question that matters is the one that is true right now. That is the principle Higher Purpose was built around, and it is the one I return to every time a relationship feels like it is drifting.

*Before you book anything, sit with this for a moment: which question are you actually asking? Are you trying to protect something that is working? Recover something that was lost? Or move toward a version of yourself that feels more whole?*

The answer changes what good care looks like. It changes what you should be walking into the room to receive.

*What question are you carrying into your wellness work right now, and has anyone ever asked you to name it before you began?*

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### **Dr. Ron**

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